

Couture *Corsetry*

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Create Corsets & Lingerie for Your Clients



Develop your technique, refine your finishing and create designs you can offer your clients with confidence.



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From the printed pattern to the finished garment

Precision sewing, pattern-making and fitting, finishing and presenting made-to-measure garments: everything you need to use the patterns in the collection.

01 How the patterns are made

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1 · How the patterns are made

Every pattern in the collection is drafted at full scale from a table of measurements. On the cover page of each file you will find:

- **Technical drawing** of the front and back, taken from the same draft as the pieces.
- **Measurements for the pattern size:** the body it is drafted for and the finished garment, in centimeters and inches.
- **Pattern pieces** and how many to cut of each.
- **Materials** with approximate quantities.
- A short **order of construction**.

On each piece you will see these markings:

Marking	What it means
Thick solid line	Cutting line. The seam allowance is already included.
Gray dashed line	Stitching line. This is where the machine goes.
Horizontal burgundy dotted line	Waistline. Use it to line up the panels and for the waist tape.
Short line at right angles to the edge (notch)	A point that must meet the one on the next piece. Mark it with a 3 mm ($\frac{1}{8}$ in) snip.
Double-headed arrow	Grainline: it runs parallel to the selvage.
Small circles	Eyelets.

Seam allowance. Corsets include 1.5 cm ($\frac{5}{8}$ in); lingerie, 0.6 cm ($\frac{1}{4}$ in). It is shown on every piece.

2 · Printing and assembling the pattern

Each pattern comes in two files. Use whichever suits you best:

A4 tiled

For printing at home. It includes an assembly map and sheets numbered by row and column (A1, A2, B1...).

Full-size plotter

A single sheet, already at 1:1 scale. Take it to a print shop that prints plans or sewing patterns (copy shop / A0 printing).

1 Print at **100 %**. In the print dialog choose “Actual size” and turn off “Fit to page”.

- 2 Measure the **test square** with a ruler: it must be 10 × 10 cm (3.94 × 3.94 in). If it is different, check your settings before printing the rest.
- 3 Trim each sheet along the gray dashed line at the top and on the left (row A and column 1 are not trimmed).
- 4 Lay each sheet over its neighbor until the gray line and the corner crosses match. Tape it down.
- 5 Assemble row by row, then join the rows. Trace the pattern onto card or brown paper if you will use it many times.

3 · Taking measurements and choosing the pattern

Take measurements over thin underwear, with the tape firm but not tight, and with the person standing straight and relaxed.

Measurement	Where
Bust	Around the fullest part of the bust, with the tape level.
Underbust	Just below the bust, where a bra band sits.
Waist	The narrowest part of the torso. Tie a piece of string and let it settle on its own.
High hip	12 cm (4¾ in) below the waist.
Hip	20 cm (8 in) below the waist, or at the widest part.
Lengths	From underbust to waist and from waist to high hip, at the front, the side and the back.

Compare these measurements with the table on the pattern's cover page. If they match within 2 cm (¾ in), you can go straight to the toile. If the difference is bigger, adapt the pattern (chapter 4).

Waist reduction. A corset closes smaller than the body: the difference is the reduction (it is in each pattern's table). To begin with, and for clients who have never worn a corset, a reduction of 4 to 6 cm (1½ to 2½ in) works best.

4 · Adapting the pattern to other measurements

Each pattern is drafted in one size. To use it for other measurements, spread the difference across the seams: that way no panel gets distorted.

- 1 Work out the difference at each line (underbust, waist, high hip): your client's measurement minus the pattern's.
- 2 The pattern is half the garment: divide the difference by 2.

- 3 Spread it across the panel seams (all of them except center front and center back). Example with 6 panels: there are 5 seams with 2 edges each, so 10 edges.
- 4 Add or remove that amount at each edge, at the height of that line, and join the points with a smooth curve.
- 5 If the length changes, lengthen or shorten every panel on the same line (for example, 2 cm / $\frac{3}{4}$ in above the waist) so the notches still match.

Example	Calculation
Client's waist 76 cm (29.9 in), pattern 70 cm (27.6 in)	Difference 6 cm → 3 cm per half → 10 edges → 3 mm per edge at the waist (about $\frac{1}{8}$ in).
Client's underbust 82 cm (32.3 in), pattern 78 cm (30.7 in)	Difference 4 cm → 2 cm per half → 10 edges → 2 mm per edge at the underbust (about $\frac{1}{16}$ in).

More than 8 cm (3 in) of difference on any line: make the change in two steps (an intermediate toile) or choose a pattern with more panels, which spreads the shape better.

5 · Materials

Material	What it is for	What to look for
Coutil or strong cotton canvas	The strength layer: it does the work	A tightly woven fabric with no stretch in any direction.
Outer fabric	The visible face	Satin, brocade, jacquard, gabardine. If it is delicate, fuse it with interfacing.
Spiral steel bones	Curved seams and sides	7 mm ($\frac{1}{4}$ in) wide; they bend sideways and follow the curve of the body.
Flat steel bones	Next to the eyelets and the busk	Rigid: they keep the closure straight.
Busk	Front closure	The length of the center front minus 2 cm ($\frac{3}{4}$ in).
5 mm eyelets with washers	Back lacing	Two-part eyelets set with a setting tool: one-part eyelets pull out.
Waist tape (2.5 cm / 1 in twill)	Stops the waist from stretching	Cotton or polyester without elastane.

6 · The toile

The toile is a test version in canvas or inexpensive coutil, with bones in the seams and closed with lacing. It is the step that separates a corset that fits beautifully from one that fits “more or less”.

- 1 Cut and sew the panels with a long stitch. Mark the waist in pencil on the outside.
- 2 Put bones in the seams (plastic, or the same steel ones) and close the front with safety pins or a busk.
- 3 Try it on, tightening the lacing gradually, without forcing it.
- 4 Pin the changes along the seams and transfer them to the pattern.

What you see at the fitting	Adjustment
The lacing gap is wider at the bottom than at the top (V shape)	It needs more hip: add at the hip seams.
The gap is wider at the top (inverted V)	It needs more at the underbust or the bust.
Horizontal wrinkles at the waist	The torso is too long: shorten between underbust and waist.
It digs into the hip when sitting	Raise the lower edge at the side by 1 or 2 cm ($\frac{3}{8}$ to $\frac{3}{4}$ in).
Gaping over the bust (overbust)	Remove bust width at the front seams.
It presses the bust down (overbust)	Add bust width at the front seams.

7 · Precision sewing, step by step

THE CRAFT · 01 PRECISION SEWING AND SHEER FABRICS

- 1 **Cutting.** Follow the grainline arrow. Cut mirrored (right sides together) so you have both sides.
- 2 **Marking.** Transfer the waist and notches to every piece with tailor’s chalk or a fabric pencil on the wrong side.
- 3 **Joining layers.** If you work outer fabric + coutil, baste them together in the seam allowance and sew both as one.
- 4 **Panels.** Join 1 to 2, 2 to 3... always starting at the waist notch and sewing upwards and downwards. That keeps the waist aligned.
- 5 **Pressing.** Press each seam open before sewing the next one.
- 6 **Channels.** Topstitch the boning channels over the seam allowances (or with channel tape) at 1.2 cm ($\frac{1}{2}$ in).

Before cutting your good fabric, check that the seams that join are the same length (“walking” the pattern: lay one piece over the other and pivot it along the stitching line). The patterns in the collection are already checked this way, with a tolerance of a few millimeters that is eased in as you sew.

8 · Refined finishing

THE CRAFT · 03 REFINED FINISHING

- 1 **Waist tape.** Stitch it inside, from center to center, along the waistline.
- 2 **Busk.** On the loop side, sew the fabric leaving openings for the studs; on the stud side, push the studs through the seam.
- 3 **Bones.** Cut them 1 cm ($\frac{3}{8}$ in) shorter than the channel, with the tips covered with paint or end caps.
- 4 **Edges.** Finish the top and bottom with bias binding in the outer fabric, machine-sewn first and slip-stitched by hand on the inside.
- 5 **Eyelets.** Mark them where the pattern shows, punch the hole and set them with the setting tool, two at a time (one on each side) so they line up.
- 6 **Lacing.** Lace it crossed from top to bottom, with two long loops at waist level to tighten from there.

9 · Presenting made-to-measure garments

THE CRAFT · 04 PRESENTING MADE-TO-MEASURE GARMENTS

When you sew for clients, the process matters as much as the garment.

- 1 **Measurement sheet.** Write down all the measurements from chapter 3, the date and the reduction she wants.
- 2 **First fitting with the toile.** This is where width, length and comfort are adjusted.
- 3 **Choosing materials.** Show fabric swatches, lacing colors and types of finish.
- 4 **Second fitting** (optional) with the garment assembled, before binding.
- 5 **Handover.** Explain how to lace it: the first few times, tightened gradually and for a few hours at a time.

Sets. A corset looks its best presented as part of an outfit: pair it with a skirt, high-waisted pants or a shirt, and with lingerie in the same fabric (the bra, bodysuit and brief patterns are made for that).

10 · The lingerie patterns

The bra, bodysuit and brief packs follow the same printing rules and markings. What changes is the fabric and the sewing:

Topic	How to work it
Fabric	Lycra, microfiber, cotton with elastane or stretch lace. The greatest stretch runs across (horizontal on the pattern).
Seams	A 3- or 4-thread serger, or a narrow zigzag on a home machine. Ballpoint needle 70 or 75 (10 or 11).
Elastic	Picot elastic for legs, neckline and armholes; apply it 10 % shorter than the edge, stretching evenly.
Gusset	Always with a cotton lining. On briefs, use the “burrito” method so no seams show.
Testing	Make the first one in scrap fabric with the same stretch as the final fabric.

Next step

Choose a pattern from the collection that looks like what you want to make, print it, measure the test square and cut your first toile. That test will tell you exactly what to adjust before you use your final fabric.